Brutal Imagination

By Cornelius Eady

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: (Pg 5) Though it's common belief

That Susan Smith willed me alive

At the moment

Her babies sank into the lake

When called, I come.

A mother needs me clothed

In hand-me-downs

And a knit cap ???? Whatever.

INTRODUCTION

On October 25, 1994, 23-year-old Susan Smith, accused a man of kidnapping her two small boys. She said that a black gunman had jumped into her Mazda while she waited at a stoplight, forced her out of the car and drove away with her sons. Nine days later, she shocked the entire nation by confessing that she herself had driven her car, with the two children strapped in the back seat, into a lake.

Over a quarter of a century later, the investigation that took place and the headlines Susan's lies created, have faded. But not for everyone . . . This selection poses the question: what if, at least during the nine days between the boys' disappearance and Ms. Smith's confession, the black man in her imagination actually existed? What would he have to say?

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SUSAN SMITH: (Pg 53-57) ***--When I left my home on Tuesday, October 25, I was very emotionally distraught***

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: I have yet

To breathe.

I am in the back of her mind,

Not even a notion.

A scrap of cloth, the way

A man lopes down a street.

Later, a black woman will say:

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"We knew exactly who she was describing."

At this point, I have no language,

No tongue, no mouth.

I am not me, yet.

I am just an understanding.

SUSAN SMITH: ***--I felt I couldn't be a good mom anymore, but I didn't want my children to grow up without a mom.***

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: I am not me, yet.

At the bridge,

One of Susan's kids cries,

So she drives to the lake,

To the boat dock. . .

I am not yet opportunity.

SUSAN SMITH: ***--I wanted to end my life so bad***

And was in my car ready to

Go down that ramp into

The water

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: My hand isn't her hand

Panicked on the

Emergency brake.

SUSAN SMITH: ***--And I did go part way, But I stopped.***

I then got out of the car.

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: Susan stares at the sinking.

My muscles aren't her muscles,

Burned from pushing.

The lake has no appetite,

But it takes the car slowly,

Swallow by swallow, like a snake.

Susan stares at the taillights

As they slide from here

To hidden.

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IMAGINED BLACK MAN: **(Pg 6)** Susan Smith has invented me because

Nobody else in town will do what
She needs me to do.
I mean: jump in an idling car
And drive off with two sad and
Frightened kids in the back.
She has given me a poisoned heart.
It pounds both our ribs, black, angry, nothing but business.
Since her fear is my blood
And her need part mythical,
Everything she says about me is true.

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(Pg 36-37) Susan fills our hands with plain objects,
Key, door handle, steering wheel,
But my hands are nothing:
A song you can't remember
The words to,
The button that pops
Off a vest, a comb that
Falls out of a pocket
Or purse.
Susan fills my lungs with air,
But what do I breathe out?
Parchment, ink, low growls, the
Blank gap between words.
Nothing fits upon my back,
Nothing actually catches my eye,
I am hidden and found,
I am North, South, East, West,
My dark skin porous, in-between.

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Susan claims my name is muscle,
Bone, calls me tissue
And sinew, fills in my blank
With the absence of her boys,
But I am water, pebble,
Silt and gravity,
Evidence under her nail.

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LITTLE BOY: (Pg 7) ***--Who are you, mister?***

IMAGINED BLACK MAN: One of the boys asks
From the eternal backseat
And here is the one good thing:
If I am alive then so, briefly, are they.
Two boys returned, three and one,
Quiet and scared, bunched together
Breathing like small beasts.
They can't place me, yet there's
Something familiar.
Though my skin and sex are different, maybe
It's the way I drive
Or occasionally glance back
With concern,
Maybe it's the mixed blessing
Someone, perhaps circumstance,
Has given us,
The secret thrill of hiding,
Childish, in plain sight,
Seen, but not seen,
As if suddenly given the power
To move through walls,
To know every secret without permission.

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We roll sleepless through the dark streets, but inside

The cab is lit with brutal imagination.

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(Pg 8-9) A few nights ago

A man swears he saw me pump gas

With the children

At a convenience store

Like a punchline you get the next day,

Or a kiss in a dream that returns while

You're in the middle of doing

Something else.

I left money in his hand.

Mr. _____who lives in ___

South Carolina,

Of average height

And a certain weight

Who may or may not

Believe in any of the

Basic recognized religions,

Saw me move like an angel

In my dusky skin

And knit hat.

Perhaps I looked him in the eye.

Ms.___saw a glint of us

On which highway?

On the street that's close

To what landmark?

She now recalls

The two children in the back

Appeared to be behaving.

Mr. ___now knows he heard

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The tires of the car
Everyone is looking for
Crunch the gravel
As I pulled up,
In the wee, wee hours
At the motel where
He works the night desk.
I signed or didn't sign the register.
I took or didn't take the key from his hand.
He looked or forgot to look
As I pulled off to park in front
Of one of the rooms at the back.
Did I say I was traveling with kids?
Who slept that night
In the untouched beds?

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(Pg 18-19) How far do you think we'd have gotten
If I'd jumped in her car, a car I wanted
For who knows what,
A woman,
And not noticed the paraphernalia?
The rattles, the child's seat?
Had smelled the spills, the dried pee,
The cloudy musk of old formula?
Even if I had pushed her out, head wild
With all I guessed I'd taken,
How many minutes,
After my foot brushed a ball,
After my eyes cooled down and focused on
The rubble of play,
How many lights do you think I'd run

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Before all the stuff they'd dropped
Over the years
Into the small cracks; the straws, the cold
Fries, the pacifier,
How long do you think the cops would listen
Had Susan not sworn
I was black, I was a bad dream,
The children didn't mean a thing
To that woman.

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(Pg 21) I am not the hero of this piece.
I am only a stray thought, a solution.
But now my face is stuck to lampposts, glued
To plate glass, my forehead gets stapled
To my hat.
I am here, and here I am not.
I am a door that opens, and out walks
No-one-can-help-you.
Now I gaze, straight into your eye,
From bulletin boards, tree trunks.
I am papered everywhere,
A blizzard called
You see what happens?

I turn up when least expected.
If you decide to buy some milk,
If you decide to wash your car,
If you decide to mail a letter,
I might tumbleweed onto a pant leg.
You can stare, and stare, but I can't be found.
Susan has loosed me on the neighbors,
A cold representative,

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The scariest face you could think of.

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(Pg 39-40) The black man in town

They thought looked like me,

Without the dreamed-up cap

And wardrobe,

The police have him now.

He sits in a small room.

They turn him this way

And that.

He'll cool there for hours.

How do you think he feels?

I whisper *we're innocent*

Into his ears.

He looks so much like me,

We could be brothers.

Already, folks

May have their doubts:

He's poor enough.

Where has he been?

He has his needs.

What do they know?

Susan has lent me

His cheekbones,

His gait.

For a while,

He is as close as

They'll ever get.

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(Pg 41) The sheriff reads off a list of things I have not done:

I have not called on the phone. I did not discard the

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Childrens' clothing they found by the highway,
I wasn't the man who robbed a convenience store
In a car the same color as Susan's. I didn't drop
Off the child they found, in Seattle, in a child's
Seat like hers; the baby someone thought they
Heard crying in the woods; not there, none of
My doing.

Bloodhounds cannot catch a whiff of me. Divers
Rake the bottom of John D. Long Lake. I give
Them a snootful of silt. Who am I? Nothing
Says the sheriff, can be ruled out. A teenaged girl
Sees a man, covered in mud, walk out of the woods.
The heat sensors of the helicopter they send fail
To light my soggy footprints. Nothing can be
Dismissed. A psychic tumbles through a dream.
He nods as the children point everywhere but
In my direction. I am zip, my
Face and reasons an educated guess.

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(Pg 38) WHAT THE SHERIFF SUSPECTS . . .

Each time the town tells the sheriff
To look harder, my nose straightens and
My hair uncurls. I rustle like wind upon
The surface of a lake. I wink just
Below Susan's cheeks.
The sheriff has shuffled my deck all week.
So many miles, so many deeds.
I do not tire. I can't stop driving. I can
Wrangle kids in broad daylight and never
Be seen or heard. I'm not doing this for ransom.
When I'm about, things simply don't add up,

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A short distance becomes too large, clocks run amok,

Stop signs change into traffic lights. Now he wonders

Why he's never noticed the way Susan's body can't sit still,

My accent rising from her alibi.

CONCLUSION

Unfounded criminal accusations across racial lines have a long history in the United States. The overwhelming majority of these cases have involved white accusers implicating black people, and the consequences have often been grievous. These hoaxes have one thing in common: The accusers are counting on stereotypes to distract the police and the public from what actually took place. In the end, these hoaxes are a clarion call, reminding us of the work we as a society still have to do to achieve racial justice.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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